Unit 5 Guided Notes — The Pythagorean Theorem

Name _____ Date _____ Period _____

$a^2 + b^2 = c^2$. Square the legs and add to find c^2. To find a leg, subtract the squares.

🎯 By the end of this unit, I can…

- Use the Pythagorean Theorem to find a missing side of a right triangle
- Apply its converse to test whether a triangle is right
- Solve real-world and coordinate-distance problems

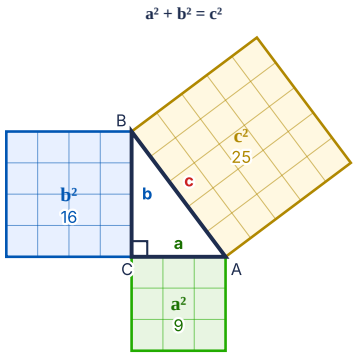
Standards: NC.8.G.6 · NC.8.G.7 · NC.8.G.8

Fill in the blanks as we go. For every example and problem, **write each step on its own line** in the space given, and box your final answer.

1 The Pythagorean Theorem

🔑 **THE THEOREM:** In a RIGHT triangle: leg² + leg² = hypotenuse². We write $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$.

a, b = legs (shorter sides) · c = hypotenuse (longest side, across from the right angle)



The two smaller squares (a^2+b^2) EXACTLY fill the biggest square (c^2)

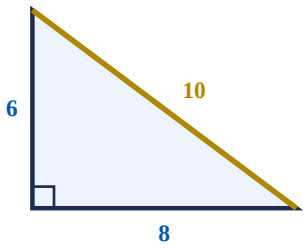
⚠️ **IMPORTANT:** The Pythagorean Theorem ONLY works on RIGHT triangles (triangles with a 90° angle)!

The two shorter sides of a right triangle are called the _____ (labeled a and b). The longest side, directly across from the right angle, is the _____ (labeled c). The theorem written as an equation: $a^2 + b^2 =$ _____. It applies only to _____ triangles.

✏ Practice: The Pythagorean Theorem

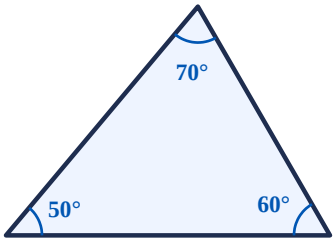
1. Score 3 Look at the right triangle. Which side is the hypotenuse?

- ○ 6
- ○ 8
- ○ 10



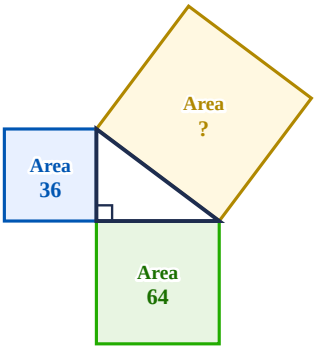
2. Score 3 A triangle has angles of 50°, 60°, and 70°. Can you use $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ on it?

- ○ Yes
- ○ No

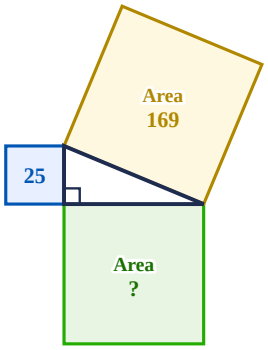


3. Score 4 The squares on the two legs of a right triangle have areas 36 and 64. What is the area of the square on the hypotenuse?

Answer: _____



4. Score 5 The square on the hypotenuse has area 169. The square on one leg has area 25. What is the area of the square on the other leg?

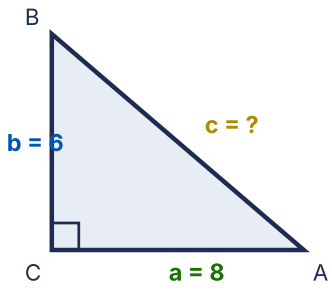


Answer: _____

2 Finding the Hypotenuse

🔑 **WHEN TO USE:** When you know BOTH LEGS and need to find the HYPOTENUSE. Square both legs and add. Then take the square root.

FIND THE HYPOTENUSE



Example: Legs are 6 and 8. Find the hypotenuse.

Step 1 — Write formula:

Step 2 — Substitute:

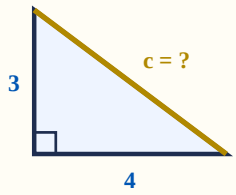
Step 3 — Square:

Step 4 — Add:

✓ Step 5 — Square root:

Practice — Find the Hypotenuse (c)

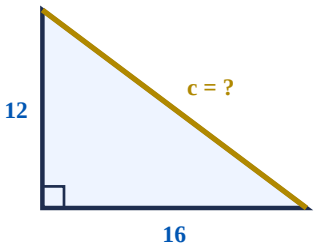
Score 3 Legs 3 and 4: $3^2 + 4^2 = c^2 \rightarrow c = ?$



c = _____

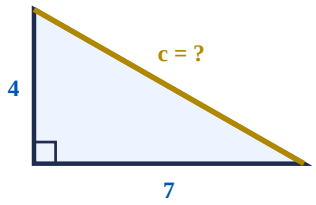
✏ Practice: Finding the Hypotenuse

1. Score 3 The legs of a right triangle are 12 and 16. Find the hypotenuse c.



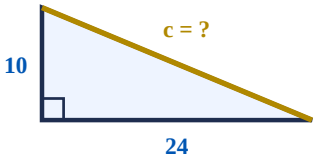
Answer: _____

2. Score 4 The legs are 4 and 7. Find the hypotenuse c. Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).



Answer: _____

3. Score 5 The legs are 10 and 24. Maria says c = 34, because 10 + 24 = 34. What is the correct value of c?



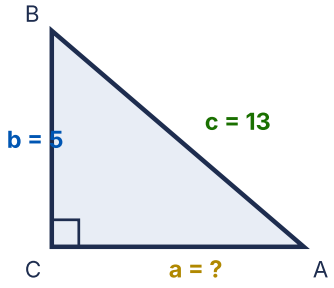
Answer: _____

3 Finding a Missing Leg

🔑 **WHEN TO USE:** When you know ONE LEG and the HYPOTENUSE. Square both numbers. Subtract the leg² from the hypotenuse². Then take the square root.

⚠️ **REMEMBER:** Finding a LEG = SUBTRACT from the hypotenuse squared. Finding the HYPOTENUSE = ADD the two legs squared.

FIND THE MISSING LEG



Example: One leg is 5, hypotenuse is 13. Find the other leg.

Step 1 — Write formula:

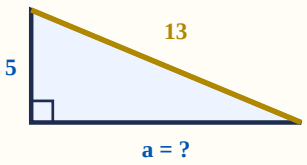
Step 2 — Substitute:

Step 3 — Square:

Step 4 — Subtract 25 (finding a LEG = SUBTRACT):

✓ Step 5 — Square root:

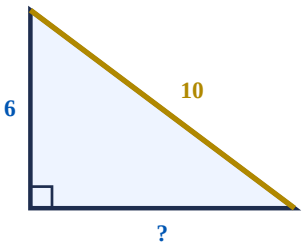
Score 4 **ERROR ANALYSIS** A student finds the missing leg when c = 13 and b = 5 by writing $a^2 = 13^2 + 5^2 = 194$. What is the fix?



- ○ They added the squares. To find a leg, subtract: $13^2 - 5^2 = 144$, so a = 12.
- ○ Nothing is wrong. a = √194 ≈ 13.9
- ○ They should add the sides: a = 13 + 5 = 18.
- ○ They should subtract the sides: a = 13 − 5 = 8.

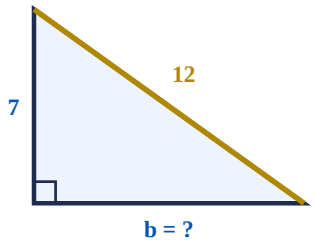
✏ Practice: Finding a Missing Leg

1. Score 3 One leg is 6 and the hypotenuse is 10. Find the other leg.



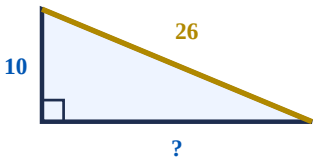
Answer: _____

2. Score 4 One leg is 7 and the hypotenuse is 12. Find the other leg. Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).



Answer: _____

3. Score 5 A right triangle has a hypotenuse of 26 and one leg of 10. What is its perimeter?

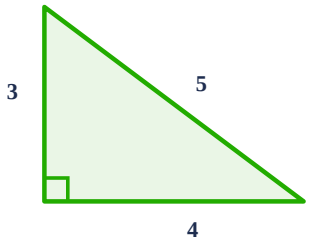


Answer: _____

4 Converse of the Pythagorean Theorem

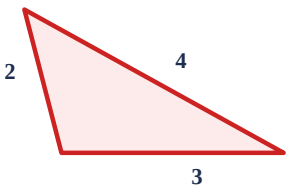
🔑 **THE CONVERSE: Converse** = the theorem turned around. Put the sides in order, smallest to largest. The largest side is c. Test: does $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$? If YES → right triangle. If NO → not a right triangle.

3, 4, 5
RIGHT triangle ✓



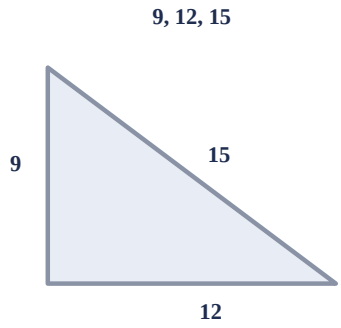
$3^2 + 4^2 = 25$ and $5^2 = 25$

2, 3, 4
NOT a right triangle ×



$2^2 + 3^2 = 13$ but $4^2 = 16$

Example: Sides 9, 12, 15. Is it a right triangle?



Step 1 — Order the sides:

Step 2 — Write the test:

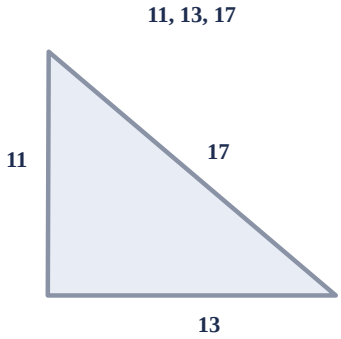
Step 3 — Substitute the two SMALLER sides:

Step 4 — Square each one:

Step 5 — Add the left side:

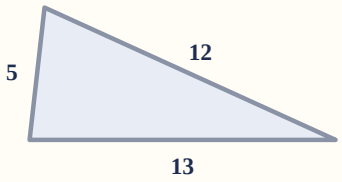
✓ Step 6 — Compare and conclude:

⚠️ **Your eyes cannot do this job.** Every triangle below is drawn to true scale. Look at **11, 13, 17**: it is *not* a right triangle, because $11^2 + 13^2 = 121 + 169 = \mathbf{290}$ while $17^2 = \mathbf{289}$. It misses by 1. The picture looks right, but it is not. Your eyes can't tell. **Always do the math.**



Quick Checks

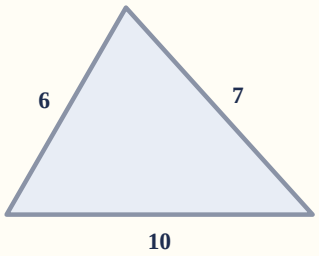
Score 3 **MC** Sides 5, 12, 13 — right triangle?



not to scale

- ○ Yes
- ○ No

Score 3 **MC** Sides 6, 7, 10 — right triangle?



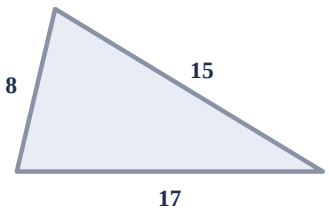
not to scale

- ○ Yes
- ○ No

✏ Practice: Converse of the Pythagorean Theorem

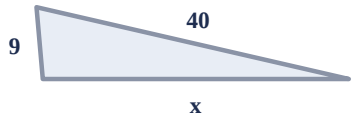
1. Score 4 A triangle has sides 17, 8, and 15. Is it a right triangle?

- ○ Yes
- ○ No



not to scale

2. Score 5 A triangle has sides 9, 40, and x. The side x is the longest. What must x be for a right triangle?



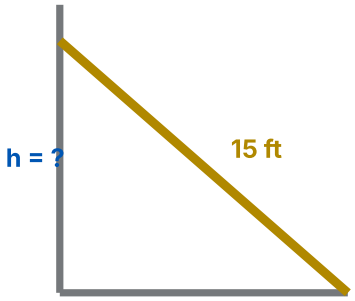
not to scale

Answer: _____

5 Word Problems

📌 **STRATEGY:** (1) Read carefully (2) Draw & label a diagram (3) Identify legs vs hypotenuse (4) Set up $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ (5) Solve step by step.

LADDER AGAINST A WALL



$9^2 + h^2 = 15^2$

Ladder Against a Wall: A ladder 15 ft long leans against a wall. The base is 9 ft from the wall. How high does it reach?

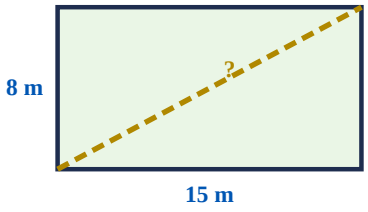
Setup:

Square & subtract:

✓ **Square root:**

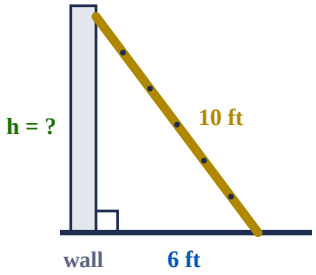
✏ Practice: Word Problems

1. Score 3 A rectangular garden is 15 m long and 8 m wide. A path goes from one corner to the opposite corner. How long is the path?



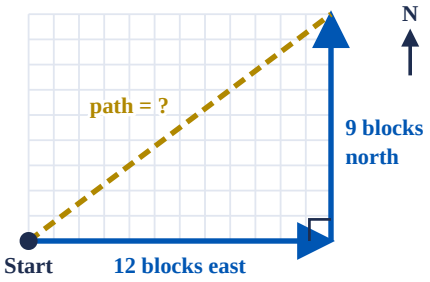
Answer: _____

2. Score 4 A 10-foot ladder leans against a wall. The bottom is 6 feet from the wall. How high up the wall does it reach?



Answer: _____

3. Score 5 Sam walks 12 blocks east, then 9 blocks north. How many blocks shorter is the straight path back to where he started?



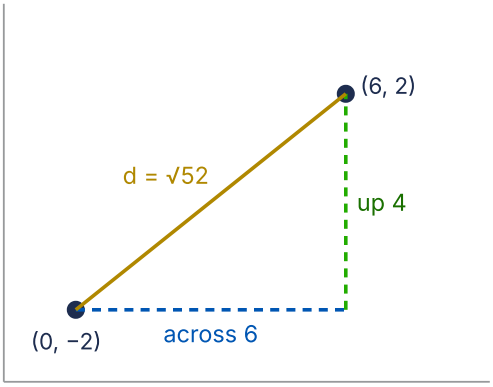
Answer: _____

6 Distance on the Coordinate Plane

📐 **HOW IT WORKS:** Connect the two points to form a right triangle. Count the boxes across: bigger x − smaller x. Count the boxes up: bigger y − smaller y. These are the legs. Then use $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$. The distance is c.

⚠️ **NO DISTANCE FORMULA NEEDED!** You already know how to do this — just use the Pythagorean Theorem!

DISTANCE = HYPOTENUSE



Example: Distance from (0, −2) to (6, 2)

Across:

Up:

Setup:

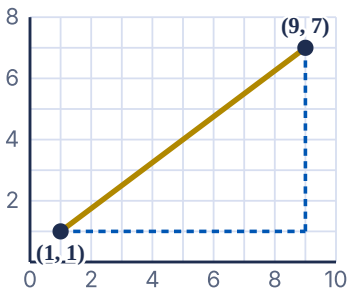
✓ **Answer:**

⚠️ **WATCH YOUR SIGNS:** When subtracting negative coordinates, subtracting a negative means ADDING! Example: 5 − (−3) = 5 + 3 = 8, NOT 5 − 3 = 2.

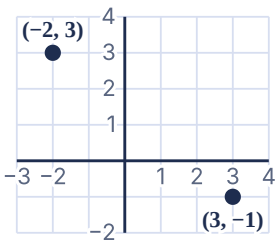
✏ Practice: Distance on the Coordinate Plane

1. Score 3 Find the distance between (1, 1) and (9, 7).

Answer: _____

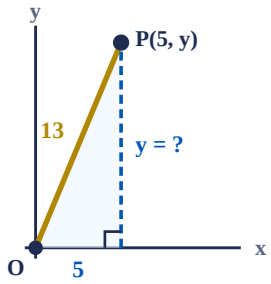


2. Score 4 Find the distance between (−2, 3) and (3, −1). Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).



Answer: _____

3. Score 5 Point P is in Quadrant I. It is 13 units from (0, 0), and its x-coordinate is 5. What is its y-coordinate?



Answer: _____

✏ Part 2 — Practice, Score 3

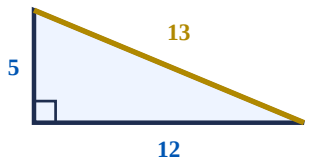
📌 **Show every step on its own line.** Box your final answer.

Every problem has a level: Score 3 Score 4 Score 5. Start with Score 3, then move up.

Score 3 Start here

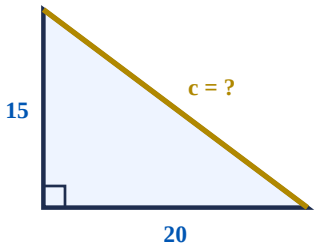
1. Score 3 A right triangle has legs 5 and 12 and hypotenuse 13. Which equation is true?

- ○ $5^2 + 12^2 = 13^2$
- ○ $5^2 + 13^2 = 12^2$
- ○ $5 + 12 = 13$



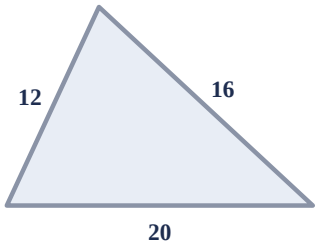
2. Score 3 The legs of a right triangle are 15 and 20. Find the hypotenuse.

Answer: _____



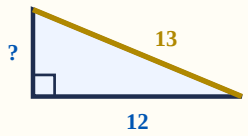
3. Score 3 A triangle has sides 12, 16, and 20. Is it a right triangle?

- ○ Yes
- ○ No



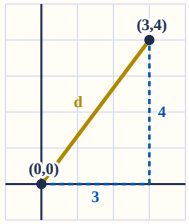
not to scale

Score 3 4) Known leg 12, hyp 13. Leg = ?



leg = _____

Score 3 5) (0,0) → (3,4). d = ?

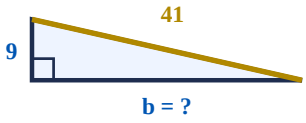


d = _____

✏ Part 2 — Practice, Score 4

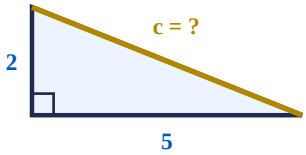
Score 4 On grade level

1. Score 4 One leg is 9 and the hypotenuse is 41. Find the other leg.



Answer: _____

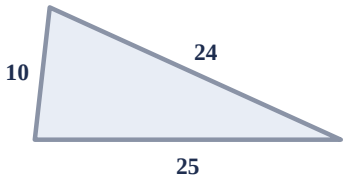
2. Score 4 The legs are 2 and 5. Find the hypotenuse. Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).



Answer: _____

3. Score 4 A triangle has sides 10, 24, and 25. Is it a right triangle?

- ○ Yes
- ○ No



not to scale

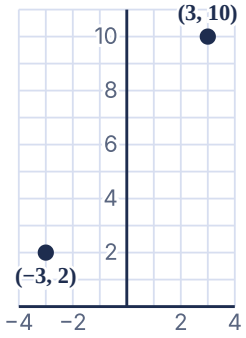
4. Score 4 A boat sails 7 miles east, then 24 miles north. How far is it from where it started?

Answer: _____



5. Score 4 Find the distance between (−3, 2) and (3, 10).

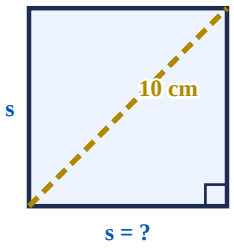
Answer: _____



Part 2 — Practice, Score 5

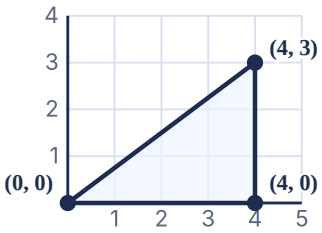
Score 5 Challenge

1. Score 5 A square has a diagonal of 10 cm. How long is each side? Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).



Answer: _____

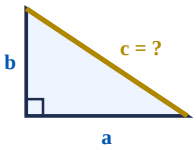
2. Score 5 A triangle has corners at (0, 0), (4, 0), and (4, 3). What is its perimeter?



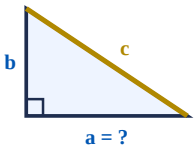
Answer: _____

3. Score 5 Which rule tells you when to ADD the squares and when to SUBTRACT them?

- ○ Add the squares to find the hypotenuse. Subtract the squares to find a leg.
- ○ Add the squares to find a leg. Subtract the squares to find the hypotenuse.
- ○ Always add the squares of the two numbers you know.
- ○ Add the two sides you know. Do not square them.

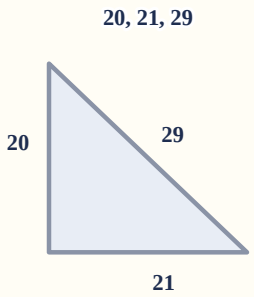


Know: a and b
Find: c



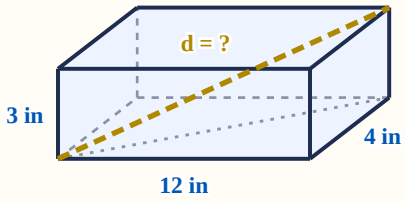
Know: b and c
Find: a

Score 5 4) Sides 20, 21, 29 — right triangle? (tap *yes* or *no*)



Answer: _____

Score 5 5) A box is 12 in long, 4 in wide, and 3 in tall. What is the longest straight stick that fits inside, from a bottom corner to the opposite top corner?



d = _____